

Traditional Romans believed that a woman's place was in the home, running the household, spinning and weaving wool, giving orders to slaves, and caring for children. Even Roman empresses wove wool. Despite this, many women had their own businesses, and they played an important public role as priestesses.

Home sweet home

Roman townhouses were of two types—private ones for the wealthy and apartments for the poor. However, if you were very rich, you might have owned a big house in the

countryside. This was a villa—a place to escape to on weekends, far from the noise and dirt of the town.

A townhouse (*domus*) was a one- or two-story building lived in by a family and its servants. Unlike a modern house, the *domus* only had a few small windows on the outside. Roman houses were designed to look in on themselves, not out. They were built around two open spaces: a hallway (*atrium*) and a garden (*peristylum*). The bedrooms, kitchen, dining rooms, servants' quarters, and storerooms were all arranged around the hallway and garden. Heating was provided by coal burning in metal braziers,

POOR PEOPLE LIVED IN THE UPPER STORIES OF APARTMENT BLOCKS, ABOVE OPEN-FRONTED SHOPS ON THE GROUND FLOOR.

